

LEAD MAGNET

The B2B Demand Generation Playbook

A channel selection and measurement framework, with economics, a 90-day plan and the failure modes to avoid.

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Creation and capture are different jobs

Demand creation changes what a market wants. Demand capture harvests intent that already exists. They need separate budgets, separate metrics and separate channels — and most underperforming programmes fail because they are trying to do both with one budget and one dashboard.

	Demand creation	Demand capture
Job	Build awareness and preference before intent exists	Convert existing intent into pipeline
Time to effect	Quarters	Weeks
Typical channels	Content, community, events, partnerships, brand, PR	SEO, paid search, review sites, retargeting, outbound
Success measure	Share of target accounts aware and engaged	Cost per qualified opportunity, conversion by stage
Common failure	Judged on last-click and defunded early	Judged on volume and scaled into poor-fit demand

Channel selection framework

Do not run a channel because a competitor does. Run it because your ACV, sales cycle, market maturity, budget and team capacity make it economically sensible. Answer the six questions below in order; the channel set falls out of the answers.

Factor	If low	If high
ACV	Under ~\$5k: self-serve capture, content, paid search	Over ~\$50k: outbound, ABM, events, partnerships
Sales cycle	Under 30 days: automated nurture, retargeting	Over 6 months: multi-persona content, coverage, community
Market maturity	New category: education, analyst and PR work	Established: comparison, review sites, differentiation

Factor	If low	If high
Budget	Under \$10k/month: two channels done properly	Over \$50k/month: portfolio with orchestration
Team size	1-3 marketers: one creation channel, one capture channel	Dedicated owners per channel
GTM motion	Product-led: in-product loops, self-serve content	Sales-led: outbound infrastructure, ABM, events

The most common portfolio error is not choosing too few channels — it is funding eleven of them at a level where none can work.

Channel reference

Grouped by fit, not by popularity. "When it works" assumes the factors above; "economics" is the honest constraint.

Channel	When it works	Economics / constraint
Content and SEO	Long cycle, considered purchase, real expertise	Slow compounding; content volume without distribution is wasted
AEO / GEO	Buyers using AI answers to shortlist	Early; measure inclusion in generated answers, not traffic alone
Email (owned)	Existing audience and lifecycle stages	Cheap to send, expensive to keep; deliverability is the constraint
Outbound	Defined ICP, ACV above ~\$15k, coverage capacity	Cost per meeting rises sharply beyond your addressable tier
Paid search	Existing, described demand	CPL rises with category competition; great capture, weak creation
Paid social	Visual categories, defined job titles	Reach cheap, qualification expensive; needs strong routing
Partnerships	Complementary products, shared ICP	Revenue share and coordination cost; slow to start
Community	Practitioner audiences, long cycles	Requires sustained contribution; cannot be bought
Events	Mid-market and enterprise, committee buying	High cost per opportunity; measurable pipeline contribution
PR and analyst	Category creation, credibility building	Indirect; hard to attribute without care
Intent data	Prioritising an existing addressable market	Noisy alone; valuable with fit and routing
ABM	Named accounts, high ACV, several stakeholders	Coordination-heavy; fails without sales ownership

Funnel architecture and benchmarks

Use your own numbers, then compare against the site's benchmark set for B2B SaaS. A leak is only actionable when you know which conversion is off-band — and remember that a benchmark band is context, not a target.

Stage	Conversion	Benchmark band (B2B SaaS)
Visitor to lead	Form or qualified action	2.5% (1.5-3.5)
Lead to MQL	Qualification	15% (10-20)
MQL to SQL	Sales acceptance	30% (20-40)
SQL to opportunity	Discovery	40% (30-50)
Opportunity to close	Win rate	25% (15-35)

Additional reference points from the same benchmark set: cold email response rate, webinar conversion, LinkedIn and Google CPL for B2B, CAC by segment, sales-cycle length by segment, and marketing budget as a share of revenue. Each is published on the site with its source, sample size and confidence note.

Compounding view: at the mid-point of these bands, a 1,000-visitor day yields roughly 25 leads, 3.75 qualified, about 1.1 opportunities — which is why "just get more traffic" rarely fixes a pipeline problem.

Campaign planning framework

One page per programme. If a campaign cannot be described in these seven fields, it is not planned yet.

Field	What belongs there
Audience	Segment, roles, account tier — sized in accounts, not percentages
Problem	The specific problem this programme addresses, in the buyer's words
Motion	Creation or capture, and the metric that proves it
Channels	The two or three channels with a stated role each
Offer	What the buyer gets, and why it is worth their time
Measurement	Leading indicator, lagging indicator, and the review date
Owner	One named person, not a team

A 90-day demand generation plan

Days 1-30: foundations and honest baseline

1. Instrument the funnel: stage definitions, conversions, response times.
2. Compute unit economics from last quarter: CAC by channel, pipeline per programme.
3. Choose the two channels the economics justify — one creation, one capture.
4. Fix routing and response time before spending more; poor follow-up destroys channel ROI.

Days 31-60: run the two channels properly

1. Build one flagship asset per creation channel; distribute it in at least three ways.
2. Launch one capture programme against existing intent (search, review sites, retargeting).
3. Set the offer and the qualification standard with sales in writing.
4. Review weekly on the leading indicator only; resist early judgement on pipeline.

Days 61-90: measure, cut, extend

1. Review cost per qualified opportunity by channel and programme.
2. Cut what cannot clear the bar; raise investment in what can.
3. Add the next channel only if capacity and economics support it.
4. Write the next quarter's plan from the numbers, and schedule the review.

Ninety days is enough to establish economics and enough to stop a channel that will not work. It is not enough to judge brand — do not defund creation on a 30-day read.

Failure modes

- Measuring leads while the business needs pipeline, then defending the leads.
- Judging creation channels on last-click and defunding them before they compound.
- Funding too many channels to a level where none of them works.
- Scaling paid capture before routing and response time are fixed.
- Treating every channel as equally appropriate regardless of ACV or cycle.
- Buying intent data with no fit model, then blaming the data for the noise.
- Running ABM without a named owner per account and a coverage promise.
- Reporting activity (sends, impressions) as if it were demand.

Companion resources: the Channel Planner to select a portfolio from your ICP, ACV and budget; the Budget Lab to allocate across the selected channels; the Experiment Planner to test changes properly; the GTM Intelligence Engine for a full diagnostic.